

modem to play online. Meanwhile, your counterpart has enough time to watch a rerun of *Walker Texas Ranger* from the moment you fire your rocket to the time it makes its way to the intended target. This is the reason why LAN parties came into the scene—ping, that dreaded unequaliser, which classifies gamers into HPBs (High Ping B*****s) and LPBs (Low Ping B*****s).

Says Topgun, a LAN party veteran who hosted FragFest IV at Chennai: “You get to scream your lungs out to a person which is not possible online, you get an awesome ping, and you can create servers at the time you need—nice, isn’t it?”

A LAN setup provides the best of both the worlds—superb ping and playability, and an easily accessible place where everyone can come in and shoot. This is why the best clans are usually formed around close-knit groups who know each other and communicate a lot more as compared to other loosely formed groups found online.

“Playing on LAN is different from playing online. The gameplay is not the same. Online, you join whichever team you can and the game is often an un-coordinated, chaotic battle that unfolds in real-time. Few people work

together properly online. One of the reasons for this is that many players don’t know each other at all, let alone understand team tactics. On LAN, all of this undergoes a quantum shift. Not only do people know each other, they also tend to use verbal commands which makes the game much more interesting,” says Ricky Kapur, admin at Kawabonka.com, an Indian online gaming service provider.

LAN parties have made baby footsteps in India. Fragfests have been thrown in Mumbai, Bangalore, Chennai, and Kolkata, usually managed by a bunch of gaming enthusiasts who come together and have a gaming binge for a day or two. All of them share an obsession for 3D games and play online regularly.

The action engaged in a LAN party is pretty much confined to the FPS arena. *Counter-Strike* is the LAN favourite, but *Quake III Arena* with some of its mods is quite popular too. *Rocket Arena* is a frequent choice for most of the *Quake III Arena* players.

“We like playing mods like *Counter-Strike*, *Rocket Arena* and *Jailbreak*, but when it comes to teamplay, *Counter-Strike* is still the tops,” says Siddhi, a gamer from Chennai.

“It’s a pain to set up—carrying your CPU and monitor around is certainly not fun, but once you’re there, it’s all worth it,” adds Grim Reaper, a Mumbai gamer.

Topgun sums it all up: “Even though it seems a lot of trouble at first—and you WILL have problems the first time—don’t let it deter you. The experience is just kick-ass and it more than makes up for all the lugging around (equipment)...it’s a gamer’s dream.”



A LAN party needs...

A big, wide space with lots of electrical outlets—a community hall, work area, cyber cafe, or even a spacious house with no parents would do just fine. The host also needs a hub to plug all the network cables into. Make sure each guest is prepared for the harrowing experience of a



Speed Phreaks: You may come across souped up rigs like these at a LAN party

Preparing your PC for the Party

Before proceeding, make sure your computer

- Has a network card installed along with the drivers. You cannot have multiplayer on your computer without a network card.
- Has your favourite games installed with all the requisite patches. Installing software at the party takes time and reduces the amount of time left to play.
- Has no outstanding hardware or software issues; it should be properly configured and tweaked. Get you favourite peripherals along. No excuses will be accepted from whiners at the end.



The gathering of geeks: The CPL events gather huge receptions worldwide, but the record goes to a LAN event held in Norway each April. The Gathering is in fact the world’s largest temporary Local Area Network. Their upper limit is 4,500, and with the crew, there are about 5,000 people in the arena. At the 1999 event, there were slightly over 4,000 attendees filling a full-size indoor Soccer stadium. The Gathering is not primarily a gaming party, but also a place where amateur developers release demos of their games.